

Space: The Final Frontier

It is one of India's fastest growing tech segments. For many, however, the DVD is still a conundrum of formats. Here's demystifying the 4.5 GB storage behemoth—the DVD

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Ever since it was launched commercially in 1997, the US market alone has sold more than 85 lakh DVD players, and 1.2 crore DVDs. The Indian market is no different. The DVD player market is one of the fastest growing in India today.

With good reason, too. A recent survey by IDC, the world's premier IT research agency, predicted that only five per cent of all PCs shipped by end-2005 will have CD-ROMs. The rest will have DVD-ROMs, or DVD combo drives or DVD and DVD writer combinations. DVD-Writers that let you back up data and copy movie DVDs are also gaining popularity amongst both DVD-movie enthusiasts, as well as, the average computer user.

Why DVD?

A typical SoHo-content creation business needs to back up images, audio, video and documents of projects—something that might run into several gigabytes. A CD, therefore, becomes unviable. You would require more of them, and also more space to store—let alone cataloguing them carefully.

The options are a bigger hard disk, a DVD-writer, or a tape drive. Investing in a new hard drive is not a portable solution. DAT, or Digital Audio Tape drives offer you 120 GB and above, but costs are a deterrent.

This is where the DVD-writer steps in. Commonly available DVD media, which offer 4.5 GB of disk space, cost around Rs 160, while a DVD-writer would cost Rs 7,000 and upwards.

The DVD, therefore, with six times the storage space of a CD, offers itself as an affordable alternative. Yes, it does take time to write a DVD, but it is far better than juggling around seven CDs.

Does this mean that it is good-bye to CD-burning? Definitely not, since all new-generation DVD-Writers burn CDs as well. However, before you get yourself a DVD-Writer, there are some factors that you need to consider.

The Format Wars

Buying the right DVD-Writer would need some research. Here are some DVD media formats available: **DVD-R and DVD-RW**

Pioneer developed and released the DVD-R and DVD-RW formats in 1997. However, Pioneer was the only manufacturer at that time with such a product, and it did face compatibility issues.

The DVD-R format is split into DVD-R (A) 'Authoring' and DVD-R (G) 'General' formats. They differ in terms of the laser used to write on them. The DVD-R (G) writes with a cheaper 650-nm (nanometre) laser, whereas DVD-R (A), intended for professional development, uses a 635-nm laser. The problem is that these formats are not compatible with each other.

DVD-R (A) drives cannot record on DVD-R (G) disks, and vice-versa. Their capacities also vary.